

BEST BUY
digit
MAY 2007


BenQ-Siemens CL71
The stylish slider

Multimedia

The BenQ-Siemens phones support the most audio formats, with the CL71 even supporting WMA. The BenQ-Siemens E61 sport media player buttons on the top; good because they won't get accidentally pressed when in a pocket. The bleu 651X and 651Z also had media player buttons, along with a good-looking media player. The BenQ-Siemens E61 and bleu 550X do not have an FM receiver, which is an important component—while being just too inexpensive to be left out!

Extras

There is voice dialling on the BenQ-Siemens CL71 and Intex AURA. Voice dialling lets you record a voice command and associate it with a number in the address book, so you can just speak the command to dial that number.

We didn't test the battery life of the phones; in what follows, we're mentioning what's been specified by the manufacturer. The talk time of the Intex AURA i1224 Black is the lowest, at two and a half hours. Strangely, its standby time is the highest (along with that of the BenQ-Siemens E61) at 200 hours. All the bleu phones have a low standby time of 2 hours, while the talk time is comparatively higher at 4 hours.

The bleu 551X, 651X, and 651Z, along with the Intex AURA, had a special feature which we hadn't anticipated on any phone in the test: when these were connected to a PC, the phone gave us a choice of whether to use them as mass storage devices or as webcams. When Webcam Mode was selected, they began working as regular webcams. The best thing is, these don't need any drivers, and the video quality is better than that of most of dedicated webcams!

Accessories

All the mobiles in this category come with the required data cables, hands-frees and chargers, so you won't need to spend extra on these—as used to be the case earlier (especially for non-premium mobile phones). The Intex AURA comes with a 1 GB microSD card, something we'd have liked to see in the Premium category.

Performance Signal reception

This was decent in most cases, though not as good as we had seen with the Nokias in the Premium segment. The BenQ-Siemens CL71 and Intex were weaker in this test, though only marginally.

Voice clarity

The BenQ-Siemens CL71 and Intex AURA seemed to us to have better earpiece clarity than the rest. The speakerphones on the BenQ-Siemens CL71, bleu 651Z, and Intex produce clear and sufficiently-audible sound. All the hands-free microphones seemed to have some sort of noise reduction that cut off ambient sound.

Speed

The BenQ-Siemens phones had a faster response time in regards the user interface. Once again, this is only marginally better than that of the other phones.

Image quality

The BenQ-Siemens E61, even with its VGA camera, did a commendable job as far as still image quality was concerned. The photos were sharp, and colours, vibrant. The bleu 651X and 651Z were also good with their 2-MP cameras. The BenQ-Siemens CL71 and the bleu 651X and 651Z were the only ones with acceptable video recording quality: all the rest brought up choppy videos.

JUST A PHONE

Mobile phones meant just to provide the basic function of communication feature in this category. Value-added features are not expected, though they certainly earn brownie points. The mobiles in this category cost below Rs 6,000. The bleu 250X and 450X, Intex infi and King, Motorola MotoFONE F3 and W220, and the Nokia 2310 and 2626 comprised this segment of our test.

Features Design And Ergonomics

The Motorola W220—a clamshell—is undoubtedly the most stylish. This is the phone that has been heavily advertised on TV as the low-cost RAZR. The other Motorola phone is the MotoFONE F3: it is the thinnest at just 9 mm, but is also the longest (11.4 cm)—it's therefore

Intex
AURAI1224 Black
30.48

Candybar
107.6 x 46.6 x 11.8
90
6
5
5/6

Dual-band
176 x 220
260
500
Proprietary
✓
6
✓
✓/✓
✓

✓/x/x
x/✓/✓/✓

microSD
✓
✓

5
1.3
1280 x 1024
x

MP3
x
✓
✓

✓
✓
150/200
Webcam

✓/✓/✓

1024

19.78

5

7

6

7

6

5

5/5

10.74

61.00

7,790



+ 1 GB memory card
- Sub-par performance